

the bigger (and smaller) names in the industry. Some companies that offer competitive prices include Esurance, Progressive, Amica, Allstate, The Hartford, and GEICO. You can also try State Farm (www.statefarm.com), which doesn't provide quotes to either of the sites mentioned above. If you've been in the military or a family member has, USAA (www.usaa.com; 800-531-8080) also offers auto insurance.

- **Plan ahead.** If your policy is due to expire in a month or two, start shopping for a new one now. Insurance companies will often give you a discount of around 10% if you sign up with them before your old coverage ends.
- **Drive safely.** Insurance companies charge less for drivers who have no violations or accidents. If you have a clean record, point it out when you're pricing policies.
- **Cut down on your driving time.** Some insurance companies charge you less if you spend less time on the road. For instance, one major insurer charges lower premiums for customers who drive fewer than 10,000 miles a year. If you join a car pool or start taking public transportation, alert your agent.
- **Choose your car carefully.** Certain types of cars are harder to damage, less expensive to repair, and less likely to be stolen than others. Insurers use this information when setting rates. You can reduce your collision and comprehensive coverage by as much as 45% if you buy a new or used car that's considered low-risk, such as a Volkswagen Beetle. Ask your agent for a list of such cars, or look at the car safety ratings from the Insurance Institute for Highway Safety (www.highwaysafety.org).
- **Get good grades.** If you're currently a student with a B average or better, on the Dean's List, or in the top 20% of your class, tell the insurance agent. Good grades can reduce your premium by up to 25%. In some cases college graduates are eligible for these discounts until they either reach age 25 or get married.